AJP Policy Document

Ending the use of lethal biological agents and poisons for population control

AJP opposes the use of lethal biological and poisons to control introduced species, for example Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV) and poisons like 1080 and Brodifacoum. Instead, AJP advocates for humane, non-lethal, and species-specific methods of population management.

Poisons and biological agents used for population control frequently cause intense and prolonged suffering, with some poisons and diseases taking hours or days to kill, leading to unnecessary animal distress. Research has shown that some commonly used poisons, such as those with a welfare impact score over 5.5[1], result in slow, painful deaths and must be reconsidered as part of a humane transition in wildlife management. For example:

- In 2018, a nationwide release of Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV) was carried out to reduce wild rabbit numbers.[2] This virus induces acute hepatitis, leading to fever, difficulty breathing, bleeding, convulsions, and ultimately death from multiple organ failure over 2-4 days.[3]
- 1080, a deadly poison, is aerially dropped to kill possums, rats, stoats, wallabies and rabbits,[4] but frequently kills non-target species such as deer,[5] pigs,[6] mice,[7]

[1] Landcare Research. (2010). "How humane are our pest control tools?" MAF Biosecurity New Zealand Technical Paper No: 2011/01 https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/4009-How-humane-are-our-pest-control-tools
[2] Landcare Research. "Rabbit biocontrol in New Zealand RHDV1 K5". Accessed May 2025. "https://www.landcareresearch.co.nz/discover-our-research/biodiversity-biosecurity/animal-pest-management/rabbit-biocontrol-in-new-zealand-rhdv1-k5/
[3] https://www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/27579-RHDV1-K5-Q-and-A
[4] Environmental Protection Authority (2024). Aerial 1080 use in Aotearoa New Zealand in 2023. /www.epa.govt.nz/assets/RecordsAPI/EPA-annual-report-on-aerial-1080-use-in-New-Zealand-2023.pd
[5] Morriss, G. A., Parkes, J. P., & Nugent, G. (2020). Effects of aerial 1080 operations on deer populations in New Zealand. *New Zealand Journal of Ecology, 44(2)*, 1-8. https://newzealandecology.org/nzje/3417
[6] E.g. Landcare Research. 2021. High effectiveness of deer-repellent Prodeer 1080 possum bait in the northern South Island high country. https://www.ospri.co.nz/assets/ResourcePDFs/Manaaki-Whenua-Landcare-Research-Molesworth-Report-2021.pdf
[7] Peterson, A. J. (2014). The long-term impacts of an aerial 1080 application on non-target forest species.

and hedgehogs; and can also kill domesticated animals such as dogs[8] and cattle,[9] and native birds such as kea,[10] karoro[11] and weka.[12] Recent proposals also include using 1080-laced baits to kill cats.[13] 1080 causes a slow and agonising death, causing vomiting, spasms and tremors over 9.5 hours on average in possums, and has been judged by animal welfare scientists to be inhumane.[14]

- Brodifacoum, an anticoagulant poison, causes animals to bleed to death over a prolonged period.[15] Like 1080, it affects non-target species, including birds and pets.[16]

Many wild animals are referred to as 'pests' in the Animal Welfare Act and only have limited protections under the Wildlife Act 1953. The use of these methods is inconsistent with the intention of the Animal Welfare Act to protect nonhuman animals, which by definition includes wildlife, from unnecessary or disproportionate harm. AJP therefore advocates for the protections that the Animal Welfare Act affords to domestic animals to be extended to all wildlife.

These animals, labelled as 'pests' in New Zealand by the Animal Welfare Act, are sentient, and did not choose to be in New Zealand, but rather are themselves the victims of past colonial actions. It is therefore both inhumane and unjust to subject them to unnecessary extreme suffering.

While AJP acknowledges the environmental challenges posed by these species, we advocate for solutions that are compassionate and effective. New technologies show great promise, such as immunocontraceptives (already used in other countries) and gene drives (the primary barrier to which is funding).[17] New Zealand must lead the way

[8] E.g. Zero Invasive Predators. 2023. Burster 1080 to Zero Predator Elimination and South Ōkārito Spot-Treatment Operation. https://www.epa.govt.nz/assets/Uploads/Documents/Hazardous-Substances/1080-reports/1080-Operational-Reports/ZIP_Aerial-1080-Operators-Report_Burster-Elimination-and-South-Okarito-spot-treatment_November-2023.pdf

[9] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority. 2019. EPA releases findings on Mapara 1080 operation. https://www.epa.govt.nz/news-and-alerts/latest-news/epa-releases-findings-on-mapara-1080/

[10] E.g. Kea Conservation Trust. (2020). Monitoring threats to kea in the Matukituki Valleys, Mt Aspiring National Park https://www.keaconservation.co.nz/projects/monitoring-threats-to-kea-in-the-matukituki-valleys-mt-aspiring-national-park/

[11] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority. (2022). 2022 West Coast South Okarito Report. ttps://www.epa.govt.nz/assets/Uploads/Documents/Hazardous-Substances/1080-reports/1080-Operational-Reports/13-10-22-HSNO-compliance-report-South-Okarito.pdf

[12] E.g. Environmental Protection Authority (2024). Aerial 1080 use in Aotearoa New Zealand in 2023. /www.epa.govt.nz/assets/RecordsAPI/EPA-annual-report-on-aerial-1080-use-in-New-Zealand-2023.pd

[13] DOC (2025) New bait to control feral cats shows promise. https://www.doc.govt.nz/news/media-releases/2025-media-releases/new-bait-to-control-feral-cats-shows-promise/

[14] Eason, C., Miller, A., Ogilvie, S., & Fairweather, A. (2011). An updated review of the toxicology and ecotoxicology of sodium fluoroacetate (1080) in relation to its use as a pest control tool in New Zealand. New Zealand Journal of Ecology, 1-20.; Sherley, M. (2007). Is sodium fluoroacetate (1080) a humane poison? Animal Welfare, 16(4), 449-458.

[15] NZVA. (2016). Wild and feral mammal control. https://nzva.org.nz/positions-advocacy/position-statements/feral/

[16] Fisher, P., O'Connor, C., Wright, G., & Eason, C. T. (2004). Anticoagulant residues in rats and secondary non-target risk. DOC science internal series, 188, 29. https://www.doc.govt.nz/documents/science-and-technical/dsis188.pdf

[17] Warburton, B., Eason, C., Fisher, P., Hancox, N., Hopkins, B., Nugent, G., ... & Cowan, P. E. (2022). Alternatives for mammal pest control in New Zealand in the context of concerns about 1080 toxicant (sodium fluoroacetate). New Zealand Journal of Zoology, 49(2), 79-121.

in ethical conservation by embracing non-lethal, compassionate and scientifically supported alternatives that protect ecosystems without inflicting suffering on sentient beings.

Key Objectives:

1. Ban the use of all lethal biological agents, including Rabbit Haemorrhagic Virus Disease (RHDV).
2. Cease the use of all poisons, including 1080 and Brodifacoum aerial drops.
3. Fund research into ethical, non-lethal alternatives for managing introduced species, such as:
    a. Immunocontraceptives for population control
    b. Fencing and habitat modification to prevent overpopulation
    c. Non-toxic deterrents and repellents
4. Ensure conservation efforts align with compassionate principles and recognise the sentience and intrinsic value of all animals.